scattered in numerous islands and regions including Fiji, Cuba, Peru and Hawaii. As many as 20 per cent of these migrants were sourced from China while 70 per cent were sourced from India.[64] Within India, Calcutta was the leading port of embarkation followed by Madras and, very rarely, Bombay. By the late 19th century, of those who left from Calcutta, two-thirds were recruited from present-day east Uttar Pradesh, a fifth from central India, a tenth from Punjab and very few from Bihar even though it was an important site initially.[65]

Closer home, indenture was used initially in migrations to Ceylon and the Malaya region but it would fade away by the late 19th century, before the massive surge in migration volumes.[66] A less known but equally significant stream of indentured migration took place within India, towards the Assamese tea plantations, with an estimated 2 million people moving over several decades in the late 19th and early 20th centuries.[67] The worst aspects of indenture were felt there as mortality rates were exceptionally high and special legislations were introduced to allow the planters the right to take penal action.

Overseas indentured migration from India was initially overwhelmingly male-dominated, and it came to a point where colonial officials had to forcefully mandate laws on gender-balanced voyages in the 1840s. This led to just a slight improvement as the share of female emigrants rose from next to nil to around 25 per cent.[68] Women and men on indenture would be dubbed ‘coolies’, a word whose origins could either lie in the Tamil word ‘kuli’, which means ‘wages’, or the Turkish word ‘Quli’, which means ‘slave’, or even the Chinese words ‘k’u’ (bitter) and ‘li’ (strength).[69] Indentured migration would start with a recruiter, known as the *arkati*, scouting ‘markets, caravanserais, railway stations, bazaars, temples and urban centres’ for likely candidates who could be persuaded to embark on the long journey.[70] In the first few decades of indenture, this would often include extreme coercion, if not outright kidnapping, as the concept of overseas travel was still new to the labourers. To overcome this, the entire process of emigration was brought under legislation with lasting legacies. In the 1840s, legal provisions introduced a ‘protector of immigrants’ at the